A Standardized Education?

By Olivia Fantini and Suli Breaks

On Standardized Testing by Olivia Fantini

Good morning boys and girls.

Welcome to the sixth grade National Assessment of Educational Progress.

Technological devices, which provide an unfair advantage, are not permitted.

If you are in possession of such a device, including but not limited to, cell phones, iPods, tablets, calculators, ***white privilege,*** parents with a college education, or a household annual income above the poverty line, please power it down now and raise your hand.

The proctor will return your device at the end of the testing period.

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INTRODUCTION

"What you know matters far less than what you can do with what you know," says Harvard education specialist Tony Wagner. You see, knowledge is available on every Internet-connected device and instant answers can be found on Google. Tests that focus on content knowledge - the tests most often and easily standardized - disengage and, ultimately, disadvantage students. Keep in mind, we're talking about the average, ***the standard****, student. Throw in those speaking English as a second language and the disconnect makes even less sense.*

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One: If Peter reads at a rate of two hundred words per minute in the fourth grade of a local private school, and his reading level is growing exponentially, how long will it take Peter to read all seven of the Harry Potter books?

I ask the ESL specialist what resources are available for my students who have just immigrated to the U.S.
She sends me a link to an online language program none of my students can afford.

Two: If Monica reads twenty words per minute in English and thirty words per minute in Spanish, in the sixth grade

of the best public middle school in Providence, how long will it take her to read to read the five-hundred-word article on "The Failings of Public Education?"

I ask the ESL specialist what resources are available for a student who spent fourth and fifth grade in a refugee camp. She tells me her boss will reach out to the family.

He never does.

Three: Students who are not proficient readers by the end of third grade are four times less likely to graduate from high school by age nineteen.

At poverty, these students become thirteen times less likely to graduate on time.

Multiply by one out of ten high school dropouts spends time in prison, divide by racism, take the square root of reality, subtract irrational numbers and unreal dreams, where will Monica be in five years?

Please put down your pencils and close your testing booklets. Wait silently while the white teacher, who grew

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up in a wealthy suburb and has never taken a standardized test, collects your materials.

Feels like a cog in the bowels of the things she despises, begins another letter to the ESL specialist who has stopped responding . . . Gives up and addresses it to herself:

Dear Olivia,

Do not think you know their struggle because you drive into their neighborhood every morning at seven and back to the east side at four.

Do not think you see through the window what they see; you are not looking through the same window. You will never be looking through the same window. It is impossible to shed a heritage of privilege. Examine your reflection in the window.

Do not try to give your students a voice by lending your own.

Your job is not to tell their story, but to be a microphone held to their lips; a stepping stool; a cheerleader.

Olivia, do not stop teaching. Do not move to a school in the suburbs. Do not switch to private education. Do not write an end to this poem, Olivia.

This isn't over.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Olivia Fantini
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TRANSITION

In 2011, Google, rated one of the best US companies to work for by Forbes magazine, released the results of a study called Project Oxygen. The study found that from an employer standpoint "… G.P.A.'s and test scores are worthless as a criteria for hiring,"

But don't the standards of the classroom prepare students for the standards of the real world? Unfortunately, in many cases the answer is NO. Today's job landscape is changing so fast, it is imperative for young professionals to be able

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to solve problems creatively and think critically. The capacity to innovate is far more important than academic knowledge. Are we too busy forcing students to color in the correct bubble on a standardized test to prepare them for the real world? We should be teaching HOW to think, not WHAT to think, because . . . You see, knowledge is available on every Internet-connected device and instant answers can be found on Google.

I Will Not Let an Exam Result Decide My Fate by Suli Breaks

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Right now
There is a kid finishing Parents' Evening in a heated
discussion with his mother
Saying, why does he have to study subjects he will never
ever use in his life?
And she will look at him blank-eyed, stifle a sigh, think for a
second and then lie
She'll say something along the lines of:

"You know to get a good job, you need a good degree and these subjects will help you get a degree, we never had this opportunity when I was younger"

And he will reply:

"But you were young a long time ago, weren't you mum?"

And she won't respond although what he implies makes perfect sense that society's needs would have changed since he was 16

But she will ignore him, grip his hand more sternly and drag him to the car

What she doesn't know is that she didn't ignore him just to shut him up

She didn't lie because they are just returning him from Parents' Evening

And an argument in the hallway would look bad on her resume

She won't lie because she had just spent the last one hour convincing a stern face teacher that she would ensure that her child studies more at home

No! She will lie simply, because she does not know any better herself

Although all her adult life, she has never used or applied

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Pythagorean theorem, Pathetic fallacy, and still does not know the value of "X"

She will rely on society to tell her that her child, who has one of the sharpest minds in the school, is hyperactive, unfocused, easily distracted and wayward

Students!

How many equations, subjects and dates did you memorize just before an exam never to use again?

How many "A" grades did you get, which were never asked for when applying for a job?

How many times have you remembered something 5 minutes just after the teacher said: "Stop writing"

Only to receive your results a month later to realize that you were only 1 mark short of the top grade?

Does that mean remembering 5 minutes earlier would've made you more qualified for a particular job?

Well, on an application form it would have

We all have different abilities, thought processes, experiences and genes

So why is a class full of individuals tested by the same means?

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So that means Cherrelle thinks she's dumb, because she couldn't do a couple sums
And if this issue is not addressed properly, it then becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy
Then every school has the audacity to have policy on equality
Huh, the irony!

Exams are society's methods of telling you what you're worth
But you can't let society tell you what you are
Cause this is the same society that tells you that abortion is wrong, but then looks down on teenage parents!
The same society that sells products to promote natural hair, looks and smooth complexion with the model on the box, half photoshopped, and has fake lashes and hair extensions
With pastors that preach charity, but own private jets
Imams that preach against greed, but are all fat
Parents that say they want "educated kids" but constantly marvel at how rich Richard Branson is
Governments, that preach peace, but endorse war, that say

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they believe so much in the importance of higher education and further learning
Then why increase tuition fees every single year?
I believed Miss Jefferson when she took me into the office, said that my exams would be imperative to my success
Because we were taught to always follow when Miss Jefferson led
Then I took Jefferson out of the equation and learned to think for myself
I realized, we were always taught to follow when misled
Huh, the irony!

Test us with tests, but the finals are never final
Because they never prepare us for the biggest test which is survival!
And what I suggest is fairly outlandish
So I don't expect everyone to understand this
Except for the kid that knows what it feels like to be worth no more than that D or that A that you get on results day
And the ones whose best stories were never good enough for your English teacher
Because apparently you missed out on key literary

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techniques
Did not follow the class plan,
And the language was too "informal" for him to understand
But then he'd reference Hamlet and Macbeth
And you'd fight the urge to express your contempt by partially clenching your fist with only your medium finger left protruding in the middle of your hand
And asking if he was aware that Shakespeare was known as the innovator of slang
Or the kid at the back of the class who thinks:
"Why am I studying something that doesn't fuel my drive?"
But when confronted with a math problem his eyes come alive

So this one is for my generation,
the ones who found what they were looking for on Google,
the ones who followed their dreams on Twitter,
Pictured their future on Instagram, accepted destiny on Facebook.
This one's for my "failures" and "dropouts", for my unemployed graduates, my shop assistants, cleaners and cashiers with bigger dreams,

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My self-employed entrepreneurs, my world-changers and my dream-chasers!
Cause the purpose of "Why I hate school, but love education" was not to initiate a worldwide debate,
But to let them know that whether 72 or 88, 44 or 68,
We will not let exam results decide our fate.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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